



STORY CONNECTION: In the above story, Ibrahim finds a wrapper and thinks that it may contain something useful. But when he gets it out of the ground, he realizes that it is empty, and this only serves to distract him from his eventual goal. If he had paid more attention to his surroundings, then perhaps he could have avoided the distraction.

Oftentimes, people look to celebrities as examples of those living an ideal life. These famous individuals ‘seem’ to have it all: wealth, talent, popularity, and even the admiration of many people. Some misguided individuals even idolize celebrities; however, it is no secret that if you analyze them and their lives objectively, there is very little to envy.



STOP AND REFLECT: Do you think celebrities are happy with all of the money and fame that they have? Do you think they are completely satisfied with their lives?

We see that many celebrities and other people with wealth and fame are not satisfied, even if they have everything they could ever want in this world. The physical comforts and notoriety that they have do not lead to complete satisfaction, and often these individuals are actually the unhappiest. Rich and famous people sometimes have to deal with harsh rejections, depression, lack of privacy, and dysfunctional relationships with their loved ones. This could be because they do not realize that they have a higher purpose, and are mainly pursuing temporary pleasures such as fame and money.

Religion can connect people to their higher purpose, and guide them to a path that will provide success for them in this world and the hereafter. It will also help them to see beyond the superficial comforts and things of this world.

In the section below, we will analyze why we require religion to fulfill our spiritual needs, and how it can dictate the best ways to fulfill our other needs as well.



THE NEED FOR RELIGION

Religion is an all-encompassing tool that helps us fulfill our higher, spiritual needs; and it also shows us the best way to fulfill our physical and social needs.

As we established in the last lesson, we have the best of purposes which is to become as close as we can to Allah ﷻ through worshiping and serving Him.



STOP AND REFLECT: How can we serve Allah ﷻ? What should we do?



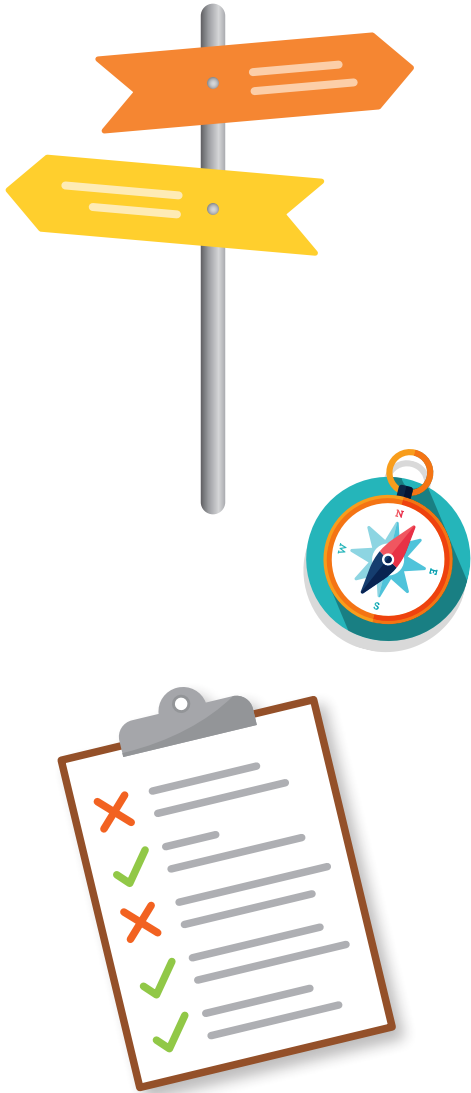
STORY CONNECTION: Think about Ibrahim in the story. He knows that he needs water to survive, and that there is something more going on—maybe even a higher purpose—but he does not know how to get there, or what to do. As he tries to figure things out and overcome the obstacles that he is facing, he realizes that he needs help and instructions to show him what to do.

Just like Ibrahim, we need instructions and guidelines in our life.

When trying to find these guidelines, we have three possible options:

1. **Following our own opinions and desires:** this option will lead us down the wrong path because we usually focus on our short-term desires, and ignore our long-term benefits. Also, we have very limited knowledge of the world.
2. **Following the opinions and ideas of other human beings who follow their own opinions and desires:** this option will also lead us down the wrong path because the people we decide to follow also have limited knowledge, and may be influenced by their own desires.
3. **Following the instructions provided by our Creator and Sustainer that are passed on to us through the Prophets ﷺ and Imāms ﷺ which also conform with our intellect:** this set of instructions comes to us in the form of the Divinely-sent religion of Islam which was taught by all of the Prophets ﷺ, perfected with the last of the Prophets ﷺ, and preserved through the 12 Imāms ﷺ.

The rest of this lesson will explore the inner guides that we have toward Islam.



OUR GUIDES: FIṬRAH (INNATE NATURE) AND ‘AQL (INTELLECT)

Fiṭrah (Innate Nature)

Once, a man came to Imām Ja’far aṣ-Ṣādiq عليه السلام and asked him about how he may get to know Allah.

Imām aṣ-Ṣādiq عليه السلام asked the man if he ever had an experience where his ship was in danger and about to sink.

The man replied in the affirmative, so the Imām عليه السلام asked him: “In that moment, did your heart feel a sense of a strong power, which made you feel like someone would help you?”

The man answered: “Yes!”

The Imām عليه السلام continued: “This feeling of hope and power that overcomes people in times of danger and need, and the feeling of support and strength given to all, is the presence of Allah, the All-Powerful. He is the only One (who can help you) in those places, when there is no one else to save you. Thus, you must always be hopeful of Him. He is always there, and He is the One who provides safety and security for all of humanity. He is Allah, the All-Great.” ²⁶

Human beings have been created in such a way that we know Allah, and desire to get closer to Him. At a very basic level, we also have been given intuition about what is right and what is wrong. This is called our **fiṭrah**, and is referred to in the Qur’ān as follows:

فُطِرَتِ اللّٰهُ الَّتِي فَطَرَ النَّاسَ عَلَيْهَا...

(Adhere to) The *fiṭrah* (innate nature) of Allah upon which He created humankind...²⁷

We do not need to be taught the knowledge of the *fiṭrah* because it is part of the way that we have been created. However, we do need to make sure that we do not get distracted away from this innate nature, and that the awareness of it grows deeper throughout our lives. This is why Allah has blessed us with another internal guide known as the intellect (*‘aql*).



‘Aql (Intellect)

The other internal guide which Allah ﷻ has blessed us with is our intellect and our ability to use reason and logic. When we observe the incredible precision and beauty in the world around us, our intellect immediately realizes that there must be a Wise and Merciful Creator who created this for our benefit. Allah says in the Qur’ān:

وَإِخْتِلَافِ اللَّيْلِ وَالنَّهَارِ وَمَا أَنزَلَ اللَّهُ مِنَ السَّمَاءِ مِنْ رِزْقٍ فَأَحْيَا بِهِ الْأَرْضَ بَعْدَ مَوْتِهَا وَتَصْرِيفِ الرِّيَّاحِ آيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَعْقِلُونَ. ٥

And (in) the variation of the night and the day, and (in) what Allah sends down of sustenance from the skies, then gives life thereby to the earth after its death, and (in) the changing of the winds, there are signs for a people who understand (use their intellect—‘aql). ²⁸

Allah ﷻ has blessed us with these two internal guides: the *‘aql* (عقل)—intellect; and the *fiṭrah* (فطرة)—our innate God-seeking nature.

Our *fiṭrah* leads us toward goodness, and our *‘aql* helps us differentiate right from wrong, and increases the knowledge we have about good and bad. The combination of these two internal guides helps us in the sense that we will be able to have a good, healthy conscience, which will then assist us to make good choices.

Our *‘aql* however is limited, and there are certain realities that we would not be able to reach on our own without Allah ﷻ sending us Prophets, Divinely-revealed Books such as the Qur’ān, and Imāms to explain what is best to us.

²⁶ Shaykh Ṣadūq, *At-Tawḥīd*, P. 231.

²⁷ Noble Qur’ān, Sūrah ar-Rūm (30), Verse 30.

²⁸ Noble Qur’ān, Sūrah al-Jāthiyah (45), Verse 5.

NEED FOR GUIDANCE TO RELIGION



STOP AND REFLECT: If Allah ﷻ is All-Knowing and All-Merciful, would He leave us without directions in life?

Our *fiṭrah* can also help us to some degree to know intuitively what is right and what is wrong. But if we make bad choices then we corrupt our *fiṭrah*, and we can lose our ability to distinguish between right and wrong.

We cover up our *fiṭrah* when we commit sins. This is like Ibrahim’s glass walls. We might not realize that there is a barrier, but it is there and it blocks us from reaching our destination. Our *fiṭrah* and *‘aql* give us a general direction, but they do not spell out things for us clearly, or give us detailed instructions.

Outside societal influences can work against our *fiṭrah* and cause us to ignore our intellect. For this reason, when people want to be ‘good’ without following the guidelines of religion, they will not be able to reach their higher purpose and achieve closeness to Allah ﷻ.

Allah ﷻ is the One who created us with a certain purpose and gave us instructions—the religion of Islam—to get us to where we need to go. These instructions come to us through external guides, such as the Prophets and the Imāms. They received instructions from Allah ﷻ, then taught us the necessary guidelines for us to reach our purpose. In the Qur’ān, Allah ﷻ says:

هُوَ الَّذِي أَرْسَلَ رَسُولَهُ بِالْهُدَىٰ وَدِينِ الْحَقِّ
He [Allah] is the One who sent His Messenger
with guidance and the true religion.²⁹



STORY CONNECTION: Think about Ibrahim in the story. He has his intellect, and he knows where he needs to go, but there are so many things he does not know. Without instructions, he is not clear about what he should do—except that he needs to rely on someone else to give him those instructions!



29 Noble Qur’ān, Sūrah al-Faṭḥ (48), Verse 28.

Activity 1.2d: Distractions and Opportunities

There are many distractions in the world around us that cover up our innate nature (*fiṭrah*) that has given to us by Allah ﷻ; likewise, there are many everyday opportunities that can help us reconnect with our innate nature (*fiṭrah*) and increase our love of Allah ﷻ and His religion. In the table below, list some examples of distractions or social influences which could cover your *fiṭrah*, as well as some measures you can take to reconnect with your *fiṭrah*.

THINGS THAT CAN COVER UP OUR INNATE NATURE (FIṬRAH)	THINGS THAT HELP US RECONNECT TO OUR INNATE NATURE (FIṬRAH)

CONCLUSION

Once we have understood our need for religion, we must strengthen our beliefs and practices through the instructions that Allah ﷻ has given us. If our purpose is to become closer to the All-Perfect and All-Just Creator, then only Allah ﷻ can tell us how to do this.



1.3 Islam: The Best Religion

OBJECTIVES

WE WILL:

- Review the origins and purpose of religion.
- Learn why every person needs to investigate in order to find a way of life.
- Learn why Islam is unchanged and timeless.
- Learn why Islam is the most advanced religion.
- Learn about how Islam is a complete way of life.

Activity 1.3a: Pre-Reading Brainstorm

1. With a partner, create a list of things (needs, hopes, and lifestyles) that you might have in common with a person who lived 1000 years ago. What are some differences?

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

2. Do people need guidance beyond those things that all human beings have in common?

3. Is it possible to address every person's needs across time and place?



STORY RECAP: Ibrahim is a young man who suddenly woke up in a garden surrounded by glass walls. He saw various messages giving him clues, and now he is trying to find a pair of glasses—as this was the most recent clue that he was mysteriously informed about.

IBRAHIM'S DREAM

Part 3: A New Challenge

It was almost mid-day, and the sun's heat was overpowering. Ibrahim continued his search for the pair of glasses that the message burned into the grass had told him to find. These glasses had to be the key to get him to the other side, to the water that he so desperately needed in order to sustain him. He thought to himself: *Who is helping me, and sending me all of these messages? Who put me here?* This world was such a mystery to him, but he knew that there had to be answers. There had to be a way to get to the other side, and to get some water. He knew what he needed to do, but he just did not know **how** to find these glasses. Ibrahim looked up at the sky and started to wonder about this world. *I want to know You better, the One who created all of this. Why is all of this here?* Ibrahim thought.

He continued to look up at the sky and watched the clouds rolling by. There were a few birds flying above him. One of them flew down and perched itself onto the tree next to him, looking at him. Ibrahim felt strange.

The bird started pecking the branch that it was sitting on. The branches on this tree were an odd shape. They folded into circles and kind of looked like...glasses? Ibrahim carefully looked again. The branches were twisted into various circles and did resemble glasses, but there was something else in the tree! Ibrahim looked closer and realized that there were at least a dozen pairs of glasses on the branches of the tree! He had finally found them, and wanted to yell with excitement!

Ibrahim stood up and started to climb the tree, grabbing onto every pair of glasses he could find, but realized that they all looked different. Some of them were small, others had really foggy lenses, and there were even some that came in different colors. *But if they are all different, how do I know which ones are the right glasses?* he wondered. Gathering all of them, he climbed down the tree, and began trying them on. The first pair was too small. The next pair had frames, but no lenses. Ibrahim was getting flustered—none of these were right. Ibrahim thought to himself that there has to be a pair of glasses that fit, have lenses, and are intact so that he can actually use them. The glasses that would lead him to the right way could not be these broken ones with missing pieces!





Next, Ibrahim picked up a pair of bright pink glasses. They were a bit chipped, but still in wearable condition. When he put them on, he was amazed. The garden was glittering with magic. He was mesmerized with the garden's beauty. For nearly an hour, he just looked at the majestic garden through this pair of pink glasses.



As he looked toward the sky, he remembered the bird that guided him toward the glasses, and how he was looking for a way out. He lost track of what he was supposed to be doing! Even though these glasses were really fascinating, it was not helping him get to the water source on the other side of the glass. He had even forgotten that he was thirsty. He took off the pink pair of glasses and sighed, looking down at his pile of misfit spectacles.



The next pair in the pile was light blue; the handles were askew but they had lenses and fit. He put them on and looked around. The garden looked the same, but there was something else he noticed. He could now see something faint on the glass walls that he was desperate to escape from. With the rest of the glasses in his hand, he walked to the closest glass wall and stared at it. There was some type of writing on the wall, but it was blurry. The lenses on this pair were not strong enough to help him.

The next pair he tried on was black, and looked to be ordinary, but when he put them on, his vision tripled. He could see very clearly that there was some type of message written on the glass wall like on a computer screen, but he could not read it too clearly. He placed this pair in the discard pile as well.



The second last pair of glasses looked better, less scuffed than the other ones before it. As soon as he wore them, he saw the glass screen come alive. *Ibrahim, after you complete these tests, you will get to the other side, which is the real world. So make everything count. Press 'Enter' to continue.* Ibrahim looked everywhere for the Enter button, but there was no such button anywhere to be seen. A lightbulb went off in his mind. With this pair of glasses, Ibrahim could not see the Enter button. The garden had also become blurry; it was as if the glasses were ignoring the garden and the world around him.

He decided to try on the last pair of glasses which seemed to be strong and sturdy, with a beautiful brown frame. They looked like what someone wise would wear. *Wasn't the old man I saw earlier wearing a pair of glasses just like these?* He put them on, and could not believe how perfect they were! He could see the garden, the sky, and the glass screen. More importantly, a red 'Enter' button was clearly visible beneath the text he had read earlier. Grinning from ear to ear, Ibrahim looked at the screen and confidently hit the 'Enter' button on the glass screen. All of a sudden, he heard the words: *Bismillāhir Raḥmānir Raḥīm* echo throughout the garden.

INTRODUCTION



STOP AND REFLECT: If you were asked to write a test, who would you want to go over the study material with? The person who designed the test and will be grading it, or your classmates? Explain your choice.

In our previous lessons, we talked about why, as human beings, we need religion. We established that there must be a Creator, and He must be All-Perfect and Infinite. We also know that there must only be One God—Allah.

We learned that we have been created in the best way with the highest purpose. We have the potential to become the best of creatures, and our purpose is to become as close to Allah ﷻ (*qurb*) as we can, by worshipping Him (*'ibādah*).

By making choices in line with what Allah ﷻ wants, and having God-conscious intentions, we are setting ourselves up to be successful in this world and the next. In order to fulfill this purpose, we concluded that we need guidelines from Allah ﷻ Himself, which we call the religion of Islam.

Although there are many ways of life, and so-called 'religions' that people may follow, there is **only one** true religion, and that religion is Islam. The other so-called religions do not meet the criteria for the true religion.



STORY CONNECTION: In the story, Ibrahim comes across several different glasses, and he is not sure which pair of glasses he needs to help him get to the other side. Some of the glasses he found could not help him reach his goal. Only one pair of glasses did this.

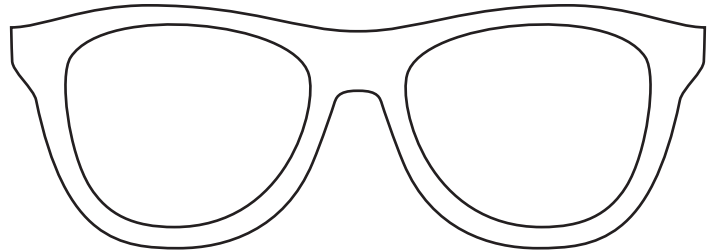


Activity 1.3b: Varying Perspectives

Examine the different pairs of glasses that Ibrahim found with their different characteristics, and decide what religion or way of life they could represent. Color code the glasses according to the story description, and add other identifying features.

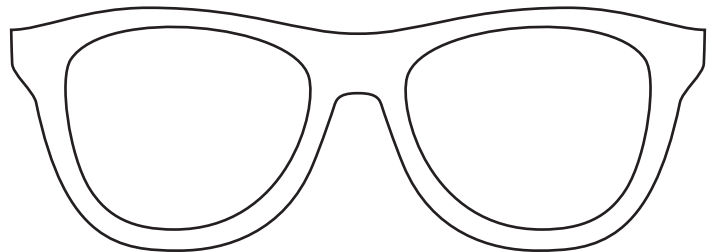
GLASSES #1

A religion or way of life these glasses represent:



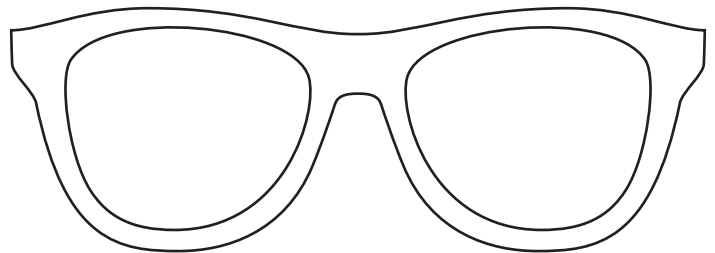
GLASSES #2

A religion or way of life these glasses represent:



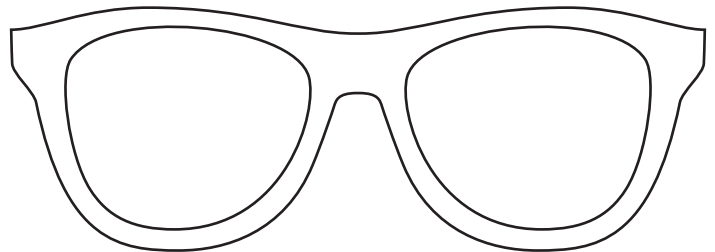
GLASSES #3

A religion or way of life these glasses represent:



GLASSES #4

A religion or way of life these glasses represent:



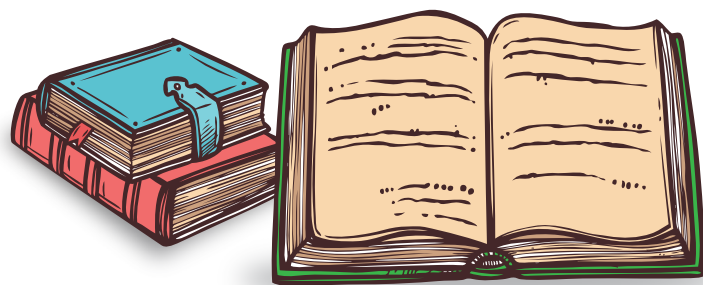
Some religions believe that there are multiple gods. However, our logic and innate nature (*fiṭrah*) have proven that there is **only one** God. Some other religions may believe in one God, but their idea of God limits God; and as we have learned, this also goes against logic and innate nature.

Some religions do not have Prophets or a Divine Book, and we have talked about the need for a Merciful Creator to send guides to His creations. Other religions may believe in some sort of guides, but these guides are not impeccable role models. The **only** religion whose teachings are consistent with logic, intellect, and innate nature is the religion of Islam. In this lesson, we will look at some of the ways in which Islam has a unique and unmatched set of teachings.

ISLAM IS UNCHANGED AND TIMELESS

Since we believe in an All-Perfect Creator, Allah, we should believe that the religion He sent down for us to follow is perfect in every way possible. The directions and guidance that He gave us, and our core beliefs, are not limited to time, nor do they change under different circumstances.

 **STOP AND REFLECT:** If human beings were responsible for changing or developing the core beliefs of religion, then why would we need a Divinely-sent religion in the first place? Explain this. (This does not mean the rules related to religion, for example specific conditions and applicable rules of how we practice certain things in Islam like rules relating to our jurisprudence, as we know these may change with time and place, and that is why we have scholars to research and teach us these things when the need arises).



It is undisputed, even by people who are not Muslims, that the Bible of Christianity and the Torah of Judaism have been altered over time. The Bible was written many years after Prophet ʿĪsā ﷺ was raised to heaven. It might have some remnants of what the disciples remembered from the Injīl, the book of Prophet ʿĪsā ﷺ, but it is imperfect. This is why there are so many different versions of the Bible today.

The Torah is also changed from the book that Prophet Mūsā ﷺ was given, although it might have some things still from the original Tawrah in it. These books were altered before the time of Prophet Muḥammad ﷺ. In contrast, Allah says in the Noble Qurʾān that He Himself will protect this Divine Book from being altered in any way; thus the Qurʾān will remain as is, and be the true guidance sent for people until the end of time.

The Christians and Jews had been told that there will be another Prophet who will come, and they had learned some of the characteristics of this final Prophet. One of the companions of Prophet Muḥammad ﷺ, Salmān al-Muḥammadī (previously known as Salmān al-Farsī), had heard about the characteristics of the Noble Prophet ﷺ from Christian monks.

As Muslims, we are unanimous on the text of the Qurʾān and what is contained therein. Even though it was revealed over 1,400 years ago, it is still intact and will always remain the exact same. There is only one version of it, and that is the original version. Even when archaeologists found some of the oldest versions of the Qurʾān from close to the Prophet's time, the words and text were always identical. This is why we see even today that there is only one version of the Qurʾān in existence. Any copy of the Qurʾān you pick up from anywhere in the world has exactly the same words and letters in the same order. No other book in history has been preserved as such, that too over a thousand years later!

Activity 1.3c: Group Game and Discussion

DIRECTIONS: In groups of 4+, play two rounds of broken telephone, and see if your group can keep a given message intact for even a brief period of time. Try increasing the complexity of the message in each round.

Once you have completed a round, answer the following questions independently.

1. What happened to the message the more it was shared?

2. Was it harder to keep the message intact the longer it became?

3. How does this help explain the miracle of the Qur’ān being unchanged?

ISLAM IS THE MOST ADVANCED RELIGION

We know that Allah ﷻ sent other Prophets whose followers became the groups that we know as Christians and Jews. If we look carefully at these other religions, we can see that at a very basic level, they are actually quite similar. Their core teachings are that people should believe in one God, that there will be a Day of Judgment, that there are Prophets which God sent for the guidance of humanity, and that people should have good manners and etiquettes (*akhlāq*). So what is it that sets Islam apart from these other religions?



STORY CONNECTION: These religions are like the last few pairs of glasses that Ibrahim found—they all seemed to work to some degree enabling Ibrahim to see that the glass screen was actually a computer touch screen, but they were not the final answer.



STOP AND REFLECT: What made the last pair of glasses perfect?

Over time, Allah ﷻ sent more Prophets with the same message: that of Monotheism (*Tawḥīd*). The laws of religion were taught more as time progressed, until we reached the laws revealed through the Qurʾān and the teachings of Prophet Muḥammad ﷺ.

After all of the other Prophets came and told their tribes and followers about the advent of the last Prophet, Allah ﷻ, in His wisdom, decided to send Prophet Muḥammad ﷺ as the final Messenger. He brought the final and most complete religion. These laws were preserved with the Imāms ؑ after him, and will remain as such until the end of time. The Imām of our time, Imām al-Mahdī ؑ, knows all of the perfected laws of Islam, but since we do not have access to him at this time, we look to our scholars (*ʿulamāʾ*) for guidance and direction.

The Prophet ﷺ said: “My example among the (other) Prophets is like the example of a house which has been built complete and beautiful, except for one final brick that is missing. Everyone who comes into the house says: ‘What a beautiful house, except for this one brick that is missing.’” The Prophet ﷺ continued: “I am like that missing brick—Prophethood comes to an end and completion through me.”¹

There are various proofs for this, including the fact that other Prophets ؑ described Prophet Muḥammad ﷺ and how he would be the last of them; the miracle of the Qurʾān itself; and what Prophet Muḥammad ﷺ told us about his own Prophethood.

Another aspect of Islam being the most advanced religion is that Islam teaches us through impeccable role models. Other religions attribute major sins to their guides, and even to the Prophets. In contrast, as Shīʿah Muslims, we believe in perfect role models like the 124,000 Prophets ؑ, and the Ahlul Bayt ؑ of the final Messenger ﷺ. They are sinless and impeccable human beings. This teaching is unique to Shīʿah Islam. The great role models that Allah presents for us set a high and noble standard for us to reach. Islam’s role models give us great examples to follow in our everyday lives, and for any situation that we may face.



1 Al-Ḥajjāj, Muslim ibn, *Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim*, Vol. 4, P. 1791..